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A Troubled Adolescence

My name is Lalchand – Lal to friends who knew me at school and college, and Lala to friends and acquaintances in the stock market. I was born in 1968 in a nondescript nursing home in Bhandup, a suburb of Mumbai. Father, or Bauji, as I called him, worked at the Bhandup factory of the engineering firm Guest Keen Williams as a plant technician till his retirement in 1992.

My parents were originally from Jaipur, and had moved to Mumbai under difficult circumstances, the details of which are not relevant to the story I am about to narrate. At the time of my birth, they were staying in the Shivram Singh chawl, off the arterial Jangal Mangal Road in Bhandup West. Bauji was just about able to make ends meet in those days, and having to provide temporary lodging for job-seeking relatives from Jaipur strained his meagre resources further. His generosity irked Ma at times, as it would fall to her to manage the house on a shoestring monthly budget.

I got into bad company early on – not my fault entirely, when you consider the environment I was exposed to in the chawl, located as it was in one of the crime-infested suburbs of the city. But looking back, I feel I was always inclined to get on the wrong side of the law, despite the decent upbringing my parents provided me.

I studied in National Education Society, among the better schools in Bhandup at the time, and well known for its Hitler-like principal whose very sight had the boys running for cover. Bauji had managed my admission through a well-connected friend of his.